

Wouldn't your first thought be to take the device back to the outlet where you bought it from, and demand a replacement or a refund?

But when your spreadsheet software (which you have purchased legally) continues to crash throughout the day, regardless of the file you open, the setting you tweaked, or the programs you closed to free up memory, do you ever think about asking the software company for a refund? What causes this distinction between our experiences with offline and online products and services?

You would have noticed, as you try to install any software, that it asks you to read its "Terms and Conditions" (T&C), and indicate that you accept them by clicking on check box. You simply cannot install the software without accepting the T&C. But how many of us even view the T&C, leave alone actually reading the 1000 word manuscripts?

One prime difference lies in the fact that we have seen stuff like home appliances and electronic goods for the past five decades, while the computer and internet have been with us only since the last twenty years, cyber laws are an even newer kid on the block.

The Internet: Its everywhere...

The fact that the internet pervades most aspects of our lives today, means that an increasing number of people have a parallel electronic existence. With millions of individuals interacting with each other, consuming online ser-



vices, performing monetary transactions, and building viewpoints through cyberspace, monitoring, controlling, and policing the internet has become one of the prime concerns of almost all gov-

ernments worldwide. The anonymous, decentralized and instantly "live" nature of the internet makes it that much tougher to assign responsibility, draw up jurisdictions, and effectively resolve genuine grievances.

Increasing cases of criminal activities being conducted through this medium have been a growing concern and need to be tackled efficiently if we are ever to harness the true potential of the internet and convince even the most reluctant individuals in being connected to it.